

SHALLOTS *Allium cepa* Aggregatum Group

Small members of the onion family, shallots are less pungent than their larger relatives and are used for pickling and cooking. Shallots can be raised from seed, although the easier option is to grow them from small bulbs called sets. They need a long growing period but can be interplanted with faster-growing crops; after the companion crops are harvested, the shallots come into their own and will make use of the available space.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

To raise shallots from seed, either start them off under cover in late winter, or outdoors, once the soil has warmed up in spring. Indoors, sow them in pots or trays, in good compost, and transplant them outside in mid-spring. Shallots need rich, well-drained soil. They will not thrive in very acidic soils, so check the pH levels of your plot and adjust the acidity with lime, if necessary. Once the seedlings are established, thin them out to approximately .75 in (2 cm) apart.

PLANTING

Plant sets outside in late winter or early spring. Rake the soil over, and then make a shallow drill, about 1 in (2.5 cm) deep.



Plant sets out in early spring.

Push each set into the drill, spacing them 6–8 in (15–20 cm) apart. Cover them gently with soil, leaving the points showing above ground level.

CROP CARE

Keep the bed free from weeds, taking care not to uproot the sets or seedlings as you work. Water sparingly, unless the weather is very warm and dry.